

High Renaissance

As Renaissance ideas circulated across Europe, the period from the 1490s to 1527 later became known as the High Renaissance. The term was first used in the early 19th century to denote the period beginning around the time of Lorenzo de' Medici's death in 1492 and the unveiling of Leonardo da Vinci's fresco *The Last Supper* in 1498, and lasting until the sack of Rome by the troops of the Holy Roman Emperor Charles V in 1527.

This short period of exceptional artistic production occurred mainly in Italy, where painters and sculptors became ever more experimental and dexterous. Artists include Leonardo, Michelangelo and Raphael, plus Giorgione and Titian in Venice, and Dürer in Nuremberg, Germany. Patronage continued to come from the Church and wealthy individuals, and the emphasis on classical traditions and realistic, dynamic styles continued to be important. The art was complex and closely observed, reflecting new attitudes towards beauty and a sense of optimism. Painters abandoned tempera, preferring more forgiving oil paints.



Leonardo, *The Lady with an Ermine*, c.1490